

XIULIN YANG

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RESEARCH INTEREST

I'm broadly interested in cognitive science-inspired NLP and computational modeling of language learning in both monolingual, multilingual, and cross-linguistic settings. My thesis focuses on improving the data sample efficiency of language models through introducing cognitively motivated inductive biases by modifying tokenization, pretraining objectives, and model architecture.

EDUCATION

Georgetown University <i>PhD in Computational Linguistics — GPA 3.97/4.00</i>	Expected 2028
University of Groningen & Saarland University <i>Erasmus Mundus Joint Master's in Language and Communication Technologies — GPA 8.5/10 (RuG), 1.2/4.0 (UdS)</i>	2023
University of Oxford <i>MSt in Linguistics, Philology and Phonetics — Distinction</i>	2021
Shandong University <i>B.A. in English Linguistics (Liangshiqiu Pilot Programme) — 90.71/100</i>	2020

PROJECTS IN PROGRESS

Agent	Yang, X. , & Hu, J. Communication with silence. (<i>ongoing project</i>).
Tokenization	Tokenization survey (<i>ongoing collaborative project</i>).
LM	Bu, L., Yang, X. , Clark, C., & Wilcox, E. (2026). What Transformer Attention Mechanism Provides the Best Fit for Human Reading Times? <i>under review</i> .
Multilingual	Yang, X. , Arnett, C., & Wilcox, E. (2026). Autoregressive Transformer Models Are Systemically Biased Toward English-like Languages. <i>Pre-registered study in progress; EMNLP under review</i> .
Benchmarking	Yang, X. , Bisazza, A., Wilcox, E., & Schneider, N. (2026). A Unified Assessment of the Poverty of the Stimulus Argument for Neural Language Models. <i>TACL, R&R</i> .

SELECTED PAPERS

EMNLP 2026	Yang, X. , Wilcox, E., & Arnett, C. (2026). Apples to Apples? Towards Comparable Crosslingual Language Model Evaluation. <i>EMNLP 2026</i> .
ACL 2026	Yang, X. , Getz, H., & Wilcox, E. (2026). Function Words as Statistical Cues for Language Learning. <i>Proceedings of ACL 2026</i> . [paper] [code] [model]
CoNLL 2026	Padovani, F., Yang, X. , Jumelet, J., & Bisazza, A. (2026). A Syntactic Annotation Toolkit for Child–Adult Interactions (CAIT). <i>CoNLL 2026</i> [paper] [code].
ACL 2025	Yang, X. , Aoyama, T., Yao, Y., & Wilcox, E. (2025). Anything Goes? A Crosslinguistic Study of (Im)possible Language Learning in LMs. <i>Proceedings of ACL 2025 (Volume 1: Long Papers)</i> . [paper] [code]
COLING 2025	Yang, X. (2025). Language Models at the Syntax–Semantics Interface: A Case Study of the Long-Distance Binding of Chinese Reflexive <i>ziji</i> . <i>Proceedings of COLING 2025</i> . [paper] [code]
EMNLP 2024	Yang, X. , Groschwitz, J., Koller, A., & Bos, J. (2024). Scope-enhanced Compositional Semantic Parsing for DRT. <i>Proceedings of EMNLP 2024</i> . [paper] [code]
COLING 2024	Otto, C., Groschwitz, J., Koller, A., Yang, X. , & Donatelli, L. (2024). A Corpus of German Abstract Meaning Representation (DeAMR). <i>Proceedings of LREC-COLING 2024</i> . [paper]

RESEARCH & WORKING EXPERIENCE

Visiting Graduate Scholar, GLINT Lab, Johns Hopkins University <i>Host: Prof. Jennifer Hu</i>	05/2026 – present
– Studying implicit coordination and convention formation through human–human, human–agent, and LLM–LLM simulations of a cooperative card game. – Built the full experimental stack: JS/Firebase web game, Python simulator with Bayesian, rule-based, and random agent types, Prolific data collection pipeline, and JHU server deployment.	
AIGC Algorithm Engineer Intern, Kunlun Tech <i>Advisor: Dr. Yuqiang Xie · LLM</i>	04/2024 – 07/2024

- Built a self-refinable LLM pipeline and finetuned LLMs for controllable story generation from summaries, and for NPC-profile-based summarization.
- Developed a domain-specific lexicon for NSFW content evaluation to support storyline design.

Research Assistant, Georgetown University (GUM)

09/2023 – 05/2024

Advisors: Prof. Nathan Schneider & Prof. Amir Zeldes · Computational Semantics

- Built a silver semantic layer within the PropBank framework for the GUM corpus, including verb-sense disambiguation and semantic role labeling.

Research Assistant, Saarland University

08/2022 – 04/2023

PI: Prof. Alexander Koller · LLM, Coreference

- Trained an end-to-end model for coreference resolution in recipes, covering zero and explicit anaphora, to support downstream AMR parsing (avg. F1 0.68 on explicit coreference).
- Evaluated zero-anaphora resolution using few-shot prompting with GPT-3.5, reaching a BLEU score of 0.30.

INVITED TALKS

Boston University, TinLab	11.2025
<i>“LLMs and Poverty of the Stimulus”</i>	
Shandong University	07.2025
<i>“Language Models as Models of Languages”</i>	
Georgetown University, Learning and Development Lab	04.2025
<i>“Multilingual Impossible Language Learning”</i>	
Shandong University	07.2024
<i>“Large Language Models as Approaches to Linguistics Research”</i>	

TEACHING & SERVICE

Teaching Assistant, Intro to Natural Language Processing	2026 Spring
Teaching Assistant, Empirical Methods in NLP (Graduate)	2025 Spring
Reviewer — ARR (Feb, Apr, Oct 2025; Jan, Mar, May 2026), SRW 2025	2025
Maintainer, AMR Bibliography	01.2024

GRANTS & AWARDS

Outstanding Reviewer Award, EMNLP 2025	2025
Merit-Based Graduate School Scholarship, Georgetown University	2023 – 2026
<i>USD 45,000 per year</i>	
George Wolf Prize, University of Oxford	07.2022
<i>Awarded for the best performance in the MSt in Linguistics, Philology and Phonetics</i>	
Erasmus Mundus Language and Communication Program Scholarship	04.2021
<i>University of Groningen & Saarland University — ~EUR 48,000; sole Chinese scholarship recipient, 2021–2022</i>	
Outstanding Graduate of Shandong University	07.2020
<i>Awarded to the top 15% of the university</i>	
Scholarship for Outstanding Students, Shandong University	2017 – 2019
<i>~CNY 6,000 total; awarded to the top 15% of the university</i>	
Merit Student, School of Foreign Languages, Shandong University	2017 – 2019
<i>Awarded to the top 20% of the college</i>	

LANGUAGES & SKILLS

Languages	Chinese (native), English (advanced), French (conversational), Dutch & German (basic)
Programming	Python, Java, JavaScript, $\text{\LaTeX}$, R, Prolog, SQL
Tools	PyTorch, Hugging Face Transformers, pandas, scikit-learn, wandb, Linux, Git, CUDA